Mother for Hire

By Linda Lee Bower

INTRODUCTION

***ANDY**: I can understand literature, symbolism, allegories, imagery, syntax and elliptical construction, but for the life of me I cannot understand why women love babies.*
***SALLY**: How in the world can a man want THREE degrees in God knows what and not want a son?*
***ANDY:** I really think it's genetic…that motherly instinct has practically ruined the female mind.*
***SALLY:** Maybe it's a control issue….men can control themselves-their education- but they don't have power over when a baby cries.*
***ANDY:** If she wants one so bad why doesn't she just become a…*
***BOTH:** "Mother for Hire"*
***SALLY:** By Linda Lee Bower.*

(ANDY is sitting at the desk, writing, munching potato chips and drinking cheap wine. SALLY breezes in, carrying a large pizza box.)

ANDY: *(Without looking up)* Well, it's about time. I had about given you up for lost.

SALLY: I had to work late, and then-

ANDY: I hope Pratt and Wiggins didn't work your poor fingers to the bone. This paper is due tomorrow, so I'll need you to type it for me tonight.

SALLY: What's this one on? The hidden symbolism of the witches in the ninety-ninth verse of the Canterbury Tales?

ANDY: Do I detect a touch of scorn for my scholarly pursuits? *(He now catches the smell of the pizza and looks up.)* At least you brought something to eat. I'm starving. *(He gets up, grabs the box, takes it to the table, and opens it.)* Wow! That is some pizza.

SALLY: All twelve toppings - double.

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ANDY: You must have robbed a bank on the way home.

SALLY: It's a celebration!

ANDY: Did you get a raise?

SALLY: Better than that.

ANDY: What could be better than a raise? I have to buy lots of books this semester.

SALLY: I'm going to be a mother.

ANDY: What?

SALLY: I'm going to have a baby.

ANDY: Sally, that is not cause for celebration.

SALLY: It is for me.

ANDY: Honey, we have been over that before. It's just not the right time.

SALLY: Will it ever be the right time for you? First you wanted to finish your B.A. degree. Then your M.A. degree. and now you are on your Ph.D. degree. What will come next? The Zh.D. degree in Esoteric and Unintelligible Poetry? Are you ever going to actually enter the working world? You are prepared for nothing except life in medieval England.

ANDY: Aw, come on. I do work.

SALLY: When?

ANDY: I teach two classes.

SALLY: In what?

ANDY: Medieval English Literature.

SALLY: Exactly.

ANDY: I suppose you want me to be a Wall Street tycoon.

SALLY: Not necessarily.

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ANDY: Listen, you have gotten to be pretty uppity since you went to work for that brokerage firm.

SALLY: What's wrong with being successful?

ANDY: I'm not going to sell my soul for money. I suppose you want me to wear a three-piece suit, too.

SALLY: You don't even want to get married.

ANDY: We just can't afford to have a baby now.

SALLY: You don't have to worry about a thing. You won't have to pay for it, because it isn't your baby.

ANDY: You're going to have a baby and it isn't mine?

SALLY: Yes and no.

ANDY: Which is it?

SALLY: Yes I'm going to have a baby, and no, it isn't yours.

ANDY: Whose is it?

SALLY: Mr. Wiggins.

ANDY: Mr. Wiggins? Your boss?

SALLY Yes.

ANDY: I'll kill you.

SALLY: Don't be silly. I'm not even pregnant yet.

ANDY: I must be missing something. I thought I understood English pretty well.

SALLY: All you have is book learning. You don't have any common sense.

ANDY: Well, will you kindly elucidate.

SALLY: I'm going to be a surrogate mother.

ANDY: A surrogate mother?

SALLY: Yes. Mr. and Mrs. Wiggins have decided to have a baby. But Mrs. Wiggins

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isn't tall enough.

ANDY: Tall enough for what?

SALLY: Don't be vulgar.

ANDY: Well, do they do it standing up?

SALLY: They want a tall baby.

ANDY: So he'll have to duck his head when he enters the world?

SALLY: I mean, they want him to grow up to be tall. Psychologists say that tall men get more respect in the business world than short men.

ANDY: *(Looking down at himself and surveying his unimpressive stature)* Oh?

SALLY: And besides, Mrs. Wiggins doesn't have time.

ANDY: Time for what?

SALLY: Don't be vulgar.

ANDY: I'm not being vulgar. I'm all agog to learn the new technology.

SALLY: Well, if you'll just let me tell you how it happened.

ANDY: I'm all ears.

SALLY: Mrs. Wiggins had an appointment to come to the office this afternoon.

ANDY: They do it by appointment?

SALLY: Andy!

ANDY: It looks like Mr. Wiggins is the one who doesn't have time, if his wife had to make an appointment to see him.

SALLY: She has a high-powered career herself, and they have to coordinate their schedules. Anyway, she came to the office this afternoon, and that's why I'm a little late.

ANDY: Why? Did you have to power up the Xerox machine?

SALLY and ANDY: Don't be vulgar.

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SALLY: She wanted to interview me. She likes me, and I fit themcharacteristics they want.

ANDY: Your typing speed?

SALLY: My height. And also my athletic abilities, particularly my great tennis game.

ANDY: They want a tall baby who plays tennis.

SALLY: Mr. Wiggins says that a good tennis game is a big advantage for a stockbroker. You know, to play with clients, and get to meet people - potential clients - at the tennis club.

ANDY: And how much more income per year does the tall baby get for his tennis game?

SALLY: More than your entire annual salary, I'm sure.

ANDY: And I suppose this tall baby has already been registered at the Harvard Business School.

SALLY: Mr. Wiggins is an alumnus.

ANDY: And what if this tall baby doesn't want to go to Harvard, or be a stockbroker, or play tennis either?

SALLY: Well, he will have all the advantages, and Mr.Wiggins will groom him, so why wouldn't he?

ANDY: What if he wants to be - heaven forbid - an impractical English Ph.D. candidate?

SALLY: Horrors.

ANDY: I'll kill you.

SALLY: Don't be silly. Anyway, that is too far away for me to deal with. I'm excited about today. I'm going to have a baby!

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ANDY: All this came about today?

SALLY: Oh, no. Mr Wiggins asked me about it a month ago.

ANDY: I always knew Wiggins was a pervert.

SALLY: And if everything works out OK - and there is no reason why it wouldn't - I can do it again.

ANDY: I don't even want you to do it once.

SALLY: Well, that's just too bad. You think your Ph.D. is so all important that you can't get married and have a baby. I'm going to have one anyway, so there.

ANDY: Why didn't you tell me you wanted a baby so much? And that you wanted to get married?

SALLY: I have told you many times.

ANDY: When?

SALLY: All I ever got was "We can't afford it," or "It just isn't the right time."

ANDY: But

SALLY: If I put it in the language of Chaucer would you understand? "Whan that Aprill with hise shoutes soote/ The droghte of March hath perced to the roote."

ANDY: But what good will it do you to be a surrogate mother? As soon as you have the baby, you will give it to somebody else.

SALLY: I'm doing it for the money.

ANDY: How much are they paying you?

SALLY: They will pay all my medical expenses, plus twenty thousand dollars.

ANDY: Twenty thousand dollars?

SALLY: All I need to do is have several babies for other women, and then I will have lots of money and I can afford to have my own baby.

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ANDY: Several?

SALLY: Sure.

ANDY: Like how many?

SALLY: I'm young. I can have babies for ten years, at least. At the rate you're going it will be ten years before you are ready to get married and have a baby. I can get in plenty of practice.

ANDY: Listen, Sally, can't we think about this a little?

SALLY: I have already thought about it.

ANDY: Just like that?

SALLY: Yes.

ANDY: How can you just do it with a strange man?

SALLY: Mr. Wiggins isn't a stranger.

ANDY: You've done it with him before? I'll kill you.

SALLY: For heaven's sake, Andy. We don't actually do it.

ANDY: *oh.* How does it work, then?

SALLY: It's done with artificial insemination.

ANDY: I don't care. It's-

SALLY: They want to start it as soon as possible. So I have to keep a temperature chart to determine when I ovulate so I can go to the fertility clinic on the right day. And, I'm sorry to tell you, we can't have relations for a while, so there won't be any, um, interference.

ANDY: For ten years? How can you do this to me?

SALLY: What do you care? You're always worried - "Did you put it in?" So afraid I might get pregnant. Well, I am going to get pregnant, but you don't have to worry about it.

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ANDY: Are you really going to get twenty thousand dollars?

SALLY: Yes, isn't it wonderful!

ANDY: Ah... well, then, in that case, perhaps

SALLY: But you aren't going to get any of it. I'm going to save it for my future baby.

ANDY: And whose baby will that be?

SALLY: Well, it depends If it still "isn't the right time" for you, then maybe I will go to a sperm bank.

ANDY: And where does that leave me?

SALLY: Where you have always been. Up in your ivory tower.

ANDY: Does this mean you won't type my papers anymore?

SALLY: I'm so excited. Mmmm. Let's eat the pizza before it gets cold. *(She separates a wedge and begins to eat.)*

ANDY: I'm not hungry anymore. *(Blackout)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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